

PLEASE NOTE: This is a DRAFT copy, provided as a preview before the lecture. The final copy with full activities and discussion slides will be released after the lecture concludes.

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Consulting

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Professional Advice and Consulting Comms: Meetings & Interviews

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(Based on contributions by Dr Rod Dilnutt; Christina Parkes; James Kotsias; Dr Piya Shedden; Chris Waddell; et al)

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Kind reminder to continue engaging with the tutorial sessions and Reesan ☺



The Reesan Case Study

The [Reesan Case Study](#)  is presented as an easily recognisable scenario that we can consider in terms of consulting assignments. We will reference Reesan as we build our consulting skills.

Also, Rod has kindly prepared an [intro slide deck - The Reesan Group Overview](#) .



Content Timeline/Recap

Define and understand consulting and communication techniques:

- (Week 6 - Marc) Negotiation Skills
- (Week 7 - Rod) Report Writing; Workshops
- **(Week 8 - Marc) Meetings; Interviews**



Professional Advice & Consulting Comms

- ▶ Key information-gathering tools in the consultant's Toolbox
- ▶ What are they, when do we use them?

Category	Description
Meetings	• Small group-based discussion • Structured agenda – usually around 1-2 points • Low level of depth accomplished, moderate breadth • Two-way communication between parties • Conversation-driven • 0.5-2 hours in length.
Interviews	• Usually one-to-one • Structured agenda – around 1-2 points • Information flow is typically one-way (one asks questions, one answers) • Medium level of depth accomplished, low breadth • Conversation-driven • 1-2 hours in length.
Workshops	• Large groups • Structured agenda – programme of work • Information flow is many-to-many • High level of depth, high level of breadth • Activity-driven (using forms, pictures, collaboration tools) • Can be >2-3 hours in length.

Agenda: Meetings

Define and understand consulting communication techniques:
Meetings

- Define the role of meetings in consulting.
- Manage effective & productive meetings.
- Identify agenda-setting techniques.
- Identify meeting success factors.

Special thanks & credits
to Christina Parkes
for designing the initial
version of this seminar.

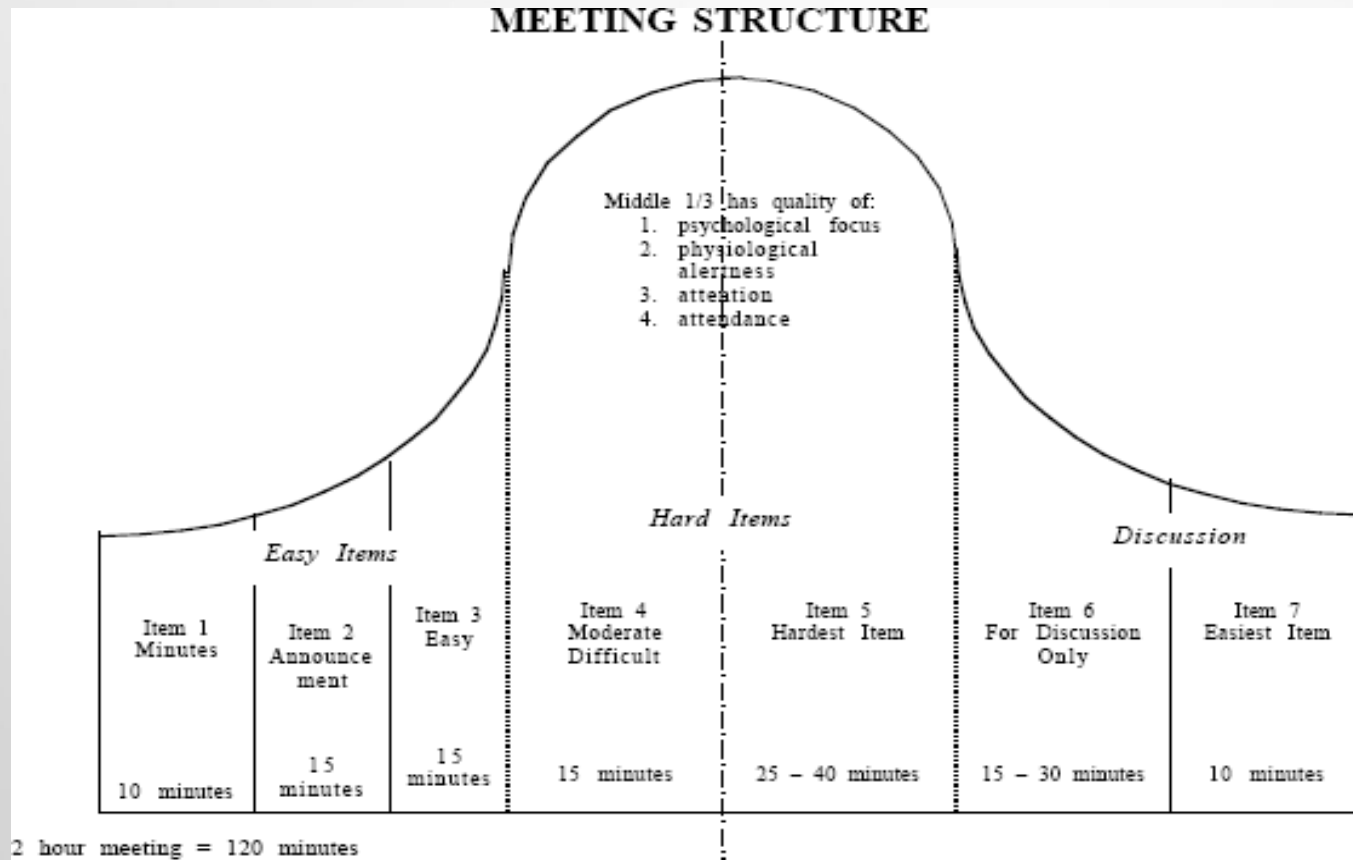
Meetings

Christina Parkes

Managing Effective Meetings

How do we define a meeting?

Assembly of persons for a specific purpose





Exercise: When to NOT call a meeting?

WHY DO YOU WANT TO CALL A MEETING?



Meetings in Consulting?

General Discussion

- ▶ To define problems
- ▶ Unstructured problem solving (Week 10)
- ▶ Objective of gathering further information
- ▶ Crucial skill to be able to do this well
- ▶ Analysis
- ▶ Frameworks

Purpose of meeting

- ▶ Information gathering?
- ▶ Understanding?
- ▶ Evaluating?
- ▶ Designing?

Meetings in Consulting?

- ▶ Establish cultural expectations from participants from the beginning
 - ▶ Provide guidelines on promptness & tardiness
 - ▶ i.e., Gold coin donation for late comers
 - ▶ One person speaks at a time
 - ▶ No private conversations
- ▶ Encourage participation during the meeting not after... why?
 - ▶ ALSO: Considerations for online and hybrid meetings?

Challenges when conducting Meetings?

Reflect also on earlier discussions on Workshops.

Challenges you may encounter when conducting meetings

- ▶ Deliberately prolonging meetings to avoid work
- ▶ Participants who have their favourite subject or personal agenda
- ▶ Indications participants have lost interest
- ▶ Indications participants do not understand subject
- ▶ Indications participants may disagree though they do not express it
- ▶ Deliberately extinguishing creativity

Exercise: Group Discussion

Which of these challenges is the most difficult to manage? Why?

Meeting Preparation I

Create an Agenda

- ▶ What is an agenda?
- ▶ It's a tool for participants to focus on accomplishment

Technique for developing an agenda using “OPQRST”

- ▶ Order & Objectives – of the process
- ▶ Process – Which technique used for information gathering?
- ▶ Question – What is the starting question?
- ▶ Recording – Which method is going to be used
- ▶ Supplies – Stationary or tools required to perform the meeting
- ▶ Timing – What is the estimated duration of the process & tasks?

Meeting Preparation II

Create a participant list

- ▶ Include key decision makers to action items

Establish roles

- ▶ Assign a support assisting with logistics, note taking, time checks and to act a witness
 - ▶ Remember to be fair and not discriminatory!

Assign a duration of the meeting

- ▶ 60 minutes is about the length of time people can concentrate with being too distracted
 - ▶ Common to have 30 min meetings too!

Commence on time and conclude on time



Conducting Meetings: Speaking

Facilitating a meeting involves 2 key tasks

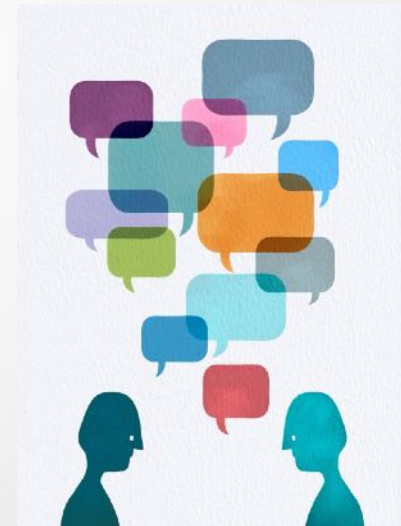
- ▶ Keeping the discussion on target
- ▶ Making sure everyone gets heard & participants' needs are met

Use data not people in discussions

- ▶ Language needs to refer to **facts** rather than opinion

Facilitating decision making

- ▶ Rather than begin with solutions, focus on a detailed analysis of where things can or do go wrong
- ▶ Seek consensus, avoid premature use of voting to arrive at decisions



Conducting Meetings: Listening

Listening

- ▶ Stay tuned to the mood of the participants
- ▶ Conclude meeting and thank attendees for their time
- ▶ After the meeting send out the minutes (no more than 48 hours)





A little rest – break for 10 minutes

Agenda: Interviews

Define and understand consulting communication techniques:
Interviews

- Conduct effective & productive interviews.
- Understand effective interviewing techniques.
- Identify common issues in interviews.
- Practice effective interviewing techniques.

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Interviews

Christina Parkes

Interview Basics

- What is the purpose of the interview - exactly?
- Are there other ways of getting the information?
- Individual or group?
- What will your roles be? (who is taking notes?)
- Location/Setting?

Types of Interviews I

Purpose of interview is to conduct a conversation with a purpose.

The features of this conversation is that it has to be

- ▶ Planned
- ▶ Directed
- ▶ Controlled

What types of interviews are there?

- ▶ Face to Face
- ▶ Telephone
- ▶ Instant messenger (IM)
- ▶ E-mail

Interview Considerations

Importance of social cues in gathering information

Anonymity of interviewees

Cost of conducting interview

Geographies and time differences

Types of Interviews II

Face-to-Face

- ▶ Social cues are important information sources
- ▶ Sufficient budget and time for travelling

Telephone interviews

- ▶ Social cues are less or not important
- ▶ Some anonymity is requested

Video

- ▶ We are more comfortable with this format after COVID-19
- ▶ Advantage of sight and sound

Instant messenger interviews

- ▶ Parties are competent in typing & using computers

E-mail interviews

- ▶ Time zones, and synchronous interviewing means for one party interviewing at night

Conducting Interviews I

Individual or group?

- ▶ Panel? 1:1?

What will your roles be?

- ▶ Asking questions or taking notes

Question format?

- ▶ Open and closed and guiding questions
 - ▶ Yes or no vs broader answers – Examples
 - ▶ Reflect on lessons in Week 7/Workshops.
- ▶ Qualitative vs quantitative
 - ▶ Narrative vs Objective data

Conducting Interviews II

Active listening

- ▶ Play it back
- ▶ Let them know you've understood
- ▶ Get them to do the same!
- ▶ Remember and reflect on Week 7!

Notes and feedback

- ▶  **Exercise: Why is this important?**

HBR – Effective Interviewing

All quotes and paraphrasing attributed to Trull (1964).

(1) "The proper kind of preparation for the interview"

- Lack of prep - "greatest single fault" – per Trull's earlier research (1962).
- Do allow time for preparation
- Do not micro-manage, e.g., rigid approach

(2) "The value of such procedures as having an outline of points to be covered and taking notes"

- Written outline is required!

HBR – Effective Interviewing

All quotes and paraphrasing attributed to Trull (1964).

(3) "The use (and misuse) of questions and questioning techniques"

(4) "The kind and amount of control that the interviewer should exercise over the discussion"

- Rapport & Guidance
- Repeat summary to give "a mirror"
- Broad questions -> narrow down
- Don't rush!
- Listening skills

(5) "The analysis and evaluation of the information obtained"

- Be aware of both "objective" and "subjective" reference points

Interview Structure – Consulting Role I

(Credits to Rod Dilnutt for scenario)

Structure:

- Total ~50 minutes
- 40% case/problem-solving
- 30% market sizing/structured thinking
- 30% behavioural & fit

1. Introduction (5 minutes)

Briefly outline structure: intro → case/problem → behavioural → wrap-up.

Warm-up: “Can you walk me through your background and why consulting appeals to you?”

Interview Structure – Consulting Role II

2. Case/Problem-Solving (20 minutes)

Consulting interviews often test structured thinking with a case scenario. Example Case: “Our client is a mid-sized beverage company experiencing declining sales over the past two years. They’ve asked for advice on how to reverse the trend. How would you approach this problem?”

Follow-up prompts:

- “What factors would you investigate first?”
- “How would you structure your analysis?”
- “What kind of data would you need, and why?”
- “Based on your initial view, what are some possible recommendations?”

Look for:

logical structure, MECE (mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive) thinking, clear communication, data-driven mindset...

Interview Structure – Consulting Role III

3. Market Sizing / Estimation (10 minutes)

Quick “guesstimate” style question: “How many cups of coffee are sold each day in Sydney?”

Candidate should break it into steps: population → % coffee drinkers → average cups/day → price assumptions.

4. Behavioural / Fit (10 minutes)

“Tell me about a time you had to influence a group without having direct authority.”

“Give an example of when you worked with a difficult stakeholder. How did you handle it?”

“Consulting often means tight deadlines. Can you share a time you managed competing priorities effectively?”

5. Wrap-Up (5 minutes)

Invite candidate questions; Provide feedback (if practice).

Summary for Week 8

This seminar has explored methods of communicating as a consultant

- Meetings
- Interviews

In the past two weeks, you have explored four structured communication styles, understood their roles, success factors, how to troubleshoot issues, and have completed simulated tasks in a consulting setting.